The Houseplant Handbook

A short guide to keeping plants alive indoors

Light, water and soil

Six plants that forgive you

What to do when it goes wrong

A plant sitter's card to fill in and sign

Written for the EtherPK demo graph

Contents

Most houseplants die of kindness. They get too much water, too little light and a pot three sizes too big, all of it well meant. The first three chapters are about those three things. The rest is six plants that put up with a beginner, a plate of a leaf to look at, a table for when something has gone wrong, and a card for the person who waters them while you are away.

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Light

Plants eat light. Everything else in this handbook is table manners. A room that looks bright to you can be dim to a plant, because your eyes adjust and its leaves do not.

The shadow test

At midday, hold your hand a foot above the spot where the plant will live, and look at the shadow it throws.

- A crisp, dark shadow means bright light. Aloes and most succulents want this.
- A soft shadow with a clear shape means medium light. This suits the widest range of houseplants.
- A faint smudge means low light. A snake plant will put up with it. Very little else will.

Distance from the window

Light falls away quickly as you move back into a room. A plant two metres from the glass gets a fraction of what the same plant gets on the sill, even when the room looks evenly lit. Move it closer before you try anything else.

What the plant tells you

- Long gaps between leaves, small new growth and a lean towards the window: too little light.
- Bleached patches or crisp brown scorch marks on the side facing the sun: too much direct sun.
- Growth on one side only: turn the pot a quarter turn each week.

Winter counts as a different room. The sun is lower and the days are short, so a plant that was happy a metre back in June may want the sill by December.

Watering

More nuanced than pouring water on it, but not much. The rule: check the soil, not the calendar.

How to check

Poke a finger into the soil. If it is dry a few centimetres down, water. If it is not, walk away. Most plants that die indoors were watered on a schedule by someone who cared about them.

How to water

- Water thoroughly until it drains from the bottom of the pot. A little and often only wets the top.
- Empty the saucer after 20 minutes. Roots standing in water rot.
- Use a pot with a drainage hole. A pretty pot with no hole is a cover, so keep the plant in a plastic pot inside it.

Why the same plant wants less in winter

Less light means slower growth, and slower growth means less water used. A monstera that wanted water weekly in July might go three weeks in January. The soil tells you this for free, which is another reason to stop using the calendar.

Too much or too little

Both can make leaves droop, so feel the soil before you do anything. Drooping in dry soil is thirst, and the plant recovers within hours. Drooping in wet soil is drowning, and more water makes it worse. Tip the plant out, look at the roots, and cut away anything brown and soft.

Soil and repotting

Roots need air as much as water. Good potting mix holds some of each. Heavy garden soil sets hard in a pot and stays wet for days, so leave it in the garden.

When to repot

- Roots come out of the drainage holes.
- Water runs straight through without soaking in.
- The plant dries out days faster than it used to.
- It has been two years and you have never done it.

How to repot

- Go one pot size up. Not three. A small plant in a huge pot sits in wet soil and rots.
- Use fresh compost, and a handful of perlite if you have it.
- Tease the roots loose a little. Do not be precious about it.
- Water it in, then leave it alone for a week to sulk.

Feeding

Feed monthly in the growing season with any balanced houseplant food, and stop in winter. Fertiliser is not medicine: a struggling plant needs its light and water sorted out first, and food on top of that can burn its roots.

Spring is the best time to repot, because the plant is about to grow into the new space. A plant in trouble can be repotted at any time of year.

Monstera

Monstera deliciosa

Family	Araceae
From	Mexico and Central America
Light	Bright, indirect. Direct sun scorches
Water	When the top few centimetres are dry
Feed	Monthly in the growing season

The one everybody starts with, and the one that rewards you for it. Big glossy leaves split as the plant matures, and it climbs anything you give it.

Give it a moss pole. It will climb slowly, and the leaves get bigger when it does. Deep shade means small leaves with no splits, and so does youth, so a young plant needs patience as well as light.

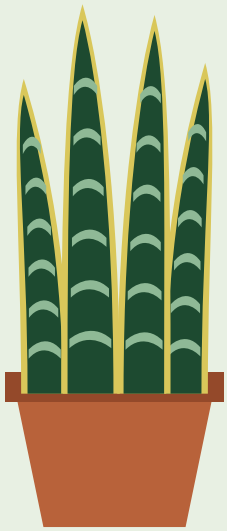
If it goes wrong

Yellow leaves are almost always too much water. Brown crispy edges mean it is too dry, or too close to a radiator.

Snake Plant

Dracaena trifasciata

Family	Asparagaceae
From	West and Central Africa
Light	Anything from a dim corner to a sunny window
Water	When the soil is completely dry
Winter	Once a month is plenty



Stiff, upright leaves banded in dark and pale green. It tolerates low light, dry air and weeks of neglect, which makes it the plant people buy after killing everything else.

It was called Sansevieria until botanists moved it, and most labels still say so. It grows slowly in a dim corner and faster near a window, and either way it would rather be forgotten than fussed over.

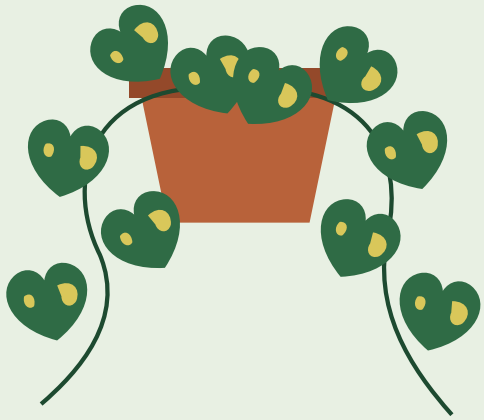
If it goes wrong

Soft, mushy leaves at the base mean the roots have been wet for too long. Let it dry right out, and cut away anything that has gone soft.

Golden Pothos

Epipremnum aureum

Family	Araceae
From	The Pacific Islands
Light	Anything but direct sun
Water	When it starts to droop slightly
Grows	Trailing from a shelf, or up a pole



The plant that survives when nothing else does. Heart-shaped leaves splashed with yellow, on stems that trail for metres. The name devil's ivy comes from how hard it is to kill.

Cut a stem just below a leaf joint and stand it in a jar of water, and it roots within a few weeks. A pothos can fill a shelf from one cutting. In low light the yellow fades and the leaves come smaller, so a window helps it keep its colour.

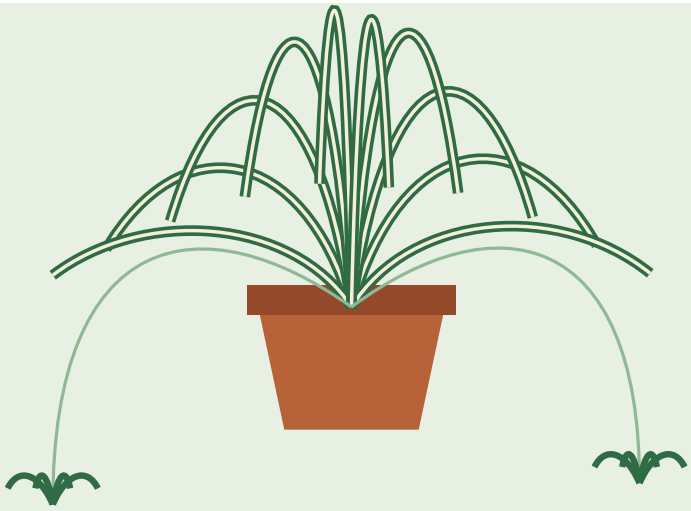
If it goes wrong

Long bare stems are normal with age. Cut them back in spring and the plant fills out from nearer the pot.

Spider Plant

Chlorophytum comosum

Family	Asparagaceae
From	Southern Africa
Light	Bright, indirect
Water	When the top half of the pot is dry
Grows	Runners with baby plants on the ends



Arching striped leaves, and long runners carrying baby plants that root the moment they touch soil. Every spider plant in the country descends from one somebody gave away.

To start a new plant, rest a baby on a small pot of compost while it is still attached to its runner, and cut the runner once it has taken. It makes a good present, and it is why you will never need to buy a second one.

If it goes wrong

Brown tips are common and mostly cosmetic. Trim them with scissors, following the shape of the leaf.

Peace Lily

Spathiphyllum wallisii

Family	Araceae
From	Colombia and Venezuela
Light	Medium, indirect. Copes with shade
Water	When it starts to droop, or just before
Flowers	Less in shade, more near a window

Not a lily. The white flower is a hooded leaf called a spathe, wrapped around the real flowers on a spike. It is famous for collapsing dramatically when thirsty and standing back up within an hour of watering.

That makes it the most honest plant in the house, and a good one to learn on. Try not to let it collapse too often, though, because each time costs it a few leaf tips.

If it goes wrong

No flowers usually means not enough light. Move it closer to a window, out of direct sun, and give it a few months.

Aloe Vera

Aloe vera

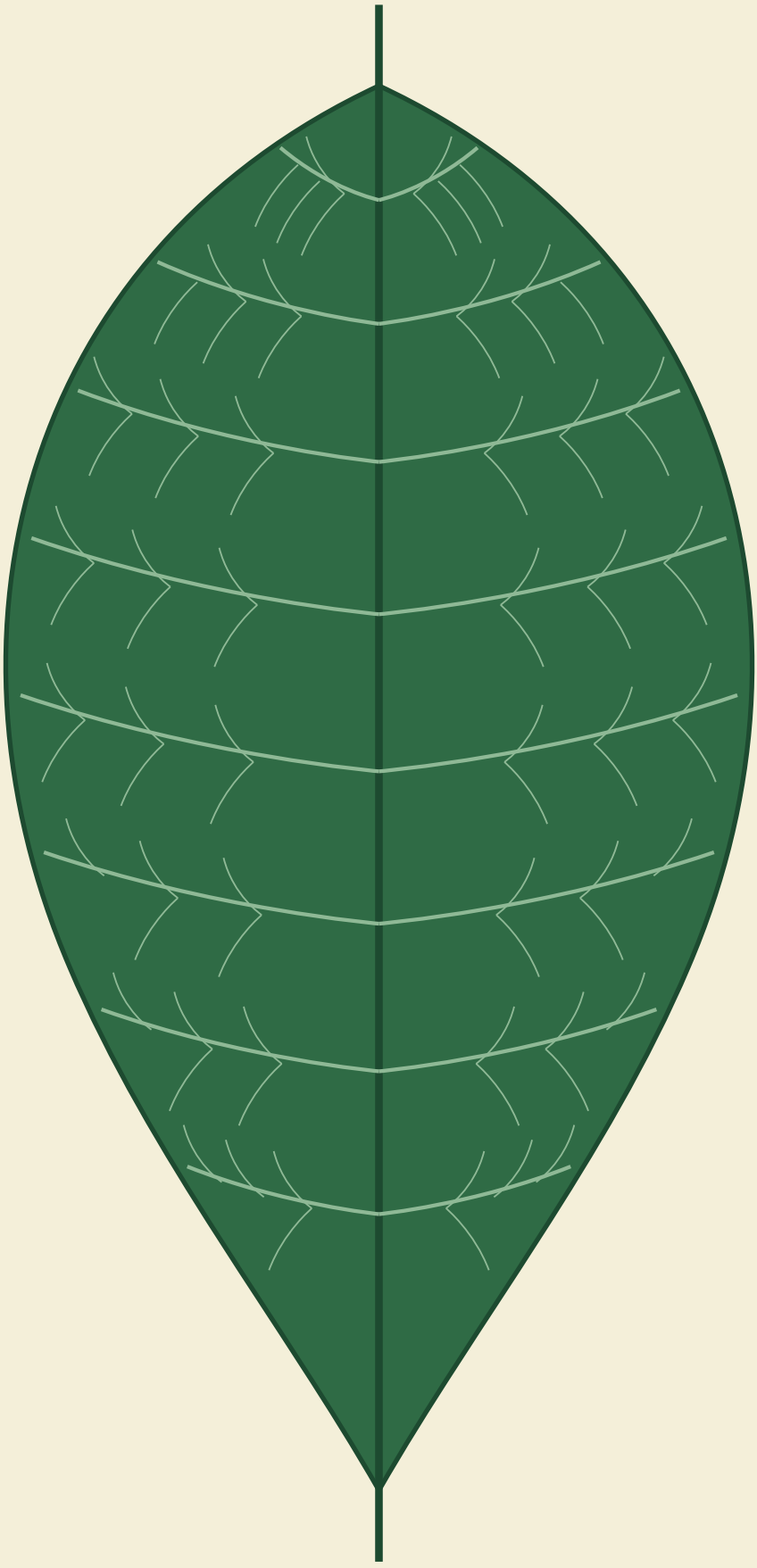
Family	Asphodelaceae
From	The Arabian Peninsula
Light	Full sun
Water	When the soil is completely dry
Soil	Gritty and fast to drain

Thick, toothed leaves full of a clear gel that people put on burns. It is a succulent that wants more light than most windowsills give, and it rots in wet soil.

Use a heavy terracotta pot, because a large aloe is top heavy and the clay dries faster than plastic. Offsets appear around the base of a happy plant, and each one can go in a pot of its own.

If it goes wrong

Flat, pale, spreading leaves mean too little light. Soft brown leaves mean too much water.



When things go wrong

Start with the soil and the light. Between them they explain most of this table.

What you see	What it probably is
Yellow lower leaves	Too much water. Let the soil dry further between waterings.
Brown, crispy edges	Dry air or a nearby radiator. Move the plant.
Bleached or scorched patches	Direct sun through glass. Move it back from the window.
Long stems and small leaves	Too little light. Move it closer to a window.
Drooping in dry soil	Thirst. Water it thoroughly and it should recover within hours.
Drooping in wet soil	Root rot. Tip it out, trim soft roots and repot in fresh compost.
Tiny flies around the pot	Fungus gnats, which breed in damp compost. Let the top dry out.
Sticky leaves	Scale or mealybugs. Wipe them off and check the plants nearby.
Fine webbing under leaves	Spider mites, which like dry air. Shower the plant and repeat weekly.
No growth at all	Probably winter. If it is June, repot it or give it more light.

Plant sitter's card

Going away? Fill this in, sign it and hand it over with the keys. It saves a phone call, and it may save the monstera.

Plant sitter

Dates away

Water

- [ ] Empty the saucers after 20 minutes
- [ ] Feed once with houseplant food
- [ ] Keep everything away from the radiators

Anything else

I agree to check the soil before I water, and not to rescue anything by drowning it.

Signed

Date